To Obey Is Better Than Sacrifice

1 Samuel 15:13-23 (KJV)

Scripture

1 Samuel 15:13-23

13 And Samuel came to Saul: and Saul said unto him, Blessed be thou of the LORD: I have performed the commandment of the LORD. 14 And Samuel said, What meaneth then this bleating of the sheep in mine ears, and the lowing of the oxen which I hear? 15 And Saul said, They have brought them from the Amalekites: for the people spared the best of the sheep and of the oxen, to sacrifice unto the LORD thy God; and the rest we have utterly destroyed. 16 Then Samuel said unto Saul, Stay, and I will tell thee what the LORD hath said to me this night. And he said unto him, Say on. 17 And Samuel said, When thou wast little in thine own sight, wast thou not made the head of the tribes of Israel, and the LORD anointed thee king over Israel? 18 And the LORD sent thee on a journey, and said, Go and utterly destroy the sinners the Amalekites, and fight against them until they be consumed. 19 Wherefore then didst thou not obey the voice of the LORD, but didst fly upon the spoil, and didst evil in the sight of the LORD? 20 And Saul said unto Samuel, Yea, I have obeyed the voice of the LORD, and have gone the way which the LORD sent me, and have brought Agag the king of Amalek, and have utterly destroyed the Amalekites. 21 But the people took of the spoil, sheep and oxen, the chief of the things which should have been utterly destroyed, to sacrifice unto the LORD thy God in Gilgal. 22 And Samuel said, Hath the LORD as great delight in burnt offerings and sacrifices, as in obeying the voice of the LORD? Behold, to obey is better than sacrifice, and to hearken than the fat of rams. 23 For rebellion is as the sin of witchcraft, and stubbornness is as iniquity and idolatry. Because thou hast rejected the word of the LORD, he hath also rejected thee from being king.

Outline

1. Partial obedience is disobedience

Saul said, "I have _____ the commandment of the LORD."

Choosing which parts of God's word to obey is still _____.

Read: 1 Samuel 15:13-15; James 2:10; Luke 6:46

2. Excuses and blame

Saul blamed the _____ for keeping the sheep.

Real repentance says "I have sinned" without a "_____."

Read: 1 Samuel 15:15-21; Genesis 3:12-13; Proverbs 28:13

3. God wants obedience more than sacrifice

To obey is better than _____.

Christian obedience flows from _____.

Read: 1 Samuel 15:22-23; Micah 6:6-8; John 14:15

Discussion questions

1. Why do you think Saul kept the best animals and King Agag?

2. What "religious" excuses do we use to cover disobedience?

3. Why is blaming others so natural, and what does it cost us?

4. How is obedience out of love different from obedience out of fear or duty?

This week

Ask God to show you one area where you have been "mostly" obeying him. Name it honestly, without excuses, and take one concrete step of full obedience this week.